F-15E WEAPONS OPERATOR WHO DOWNED NUMEROUS DRONES BECOMES THE FIRST USAF WOMAN TO GET THE SILVER STAR.

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USAF Captain Lacie Hester is a weapons systems operator on the F-15E Strike Eagle based at RAF Lakenheath in Suffolk (Picture: US Department of Defense)



The Silver Star is the third-highest military combat decoration that can be awarded to a member of the United States Armed Forces.

A US Air Force F-15E weapons systems operator has been awarded the Silver Star for her role in shooting down Iranian and Houthi one-way attack drones and missiles that were launched against Israel.

Captain Lacie Hester, who is based at RAF Lakenheath in Suffolk*, was the first woman in the USAF to receive the medal for her gallantry in repelling the large-scale attack.*

Capt. Hester, who crews the F-15E Strike Eagle with the 494th Fighter Squadron, played a critical role during the 13-14 April 2024 operation, which saw more than 300 drones and missiles launched from Iran and Houthi-controlled Yemen.

Despite facing aircraft emergencies and hostile fire, she and her pilot, Major Benjamin Coffey, directed coalition forces in what has been described as the largest air-to-air engagement since the Vietnam War.

Both Capt. Hester and Maj Coffey received the Silver Star, being recognized for their heroism as airborne mission commanders.

They not only engaged enemy drones in their Strike Eagle, but also coordinated coalition air assets while operating in the face of falling debris from hostile fire.

Capt. Hester's award makes her the first woman in the USAF and only the 10th woman across the Department of Defense to receive the Silver Star, the third-highest US military decoration for valor.

The coalition, which included the UK, destroyed 99 per cent of incoming threats during the attack, safeguarding critical infrastructure in Israel.



RAF Lakenheath honors decorated Airmen for repelling mass Iranian drone attack (Picture: US Dept of Defense)

F-15E Strike Eagles from RAF Lakenheath and Seymour Johnson Air Force Base intercepted over 80 drones, with Capt. Hester and Maj Coffey at the forefront of the action.

"We all fell into an execution rhythm: call, shoot and confirm the target was destroyed before we moved on to the next task we had to accomplish to keep everyone safe," said Lieutenant Colonel Timothy Causey, the commander of the 494th Fighter Squadron.

While the two Silver Stars were the highest accolades presented, other airmen were also recognized for their extraordinary contributions.

Six Distinguished Flying Crosses with the valor device, four Distinguished Flying Crosses with the combat device and four additional Distinguished Flying Crosses were awarded.

Master Sergeant Timothy Adams, the lead production superintendent, and Major Clayton Wicks received the Bronze Star Medal for their leadership on the ground.

MSgt Adams commended his team for maintaining composure and efficiency under the extreme pressures of active base defense.

"People, mission. People, mission. That’s all that was in my head," he said.

"People first, keep them safe. Make sure they're doing what they need to do and safe. I was just focused on everything going around. I didn’t have time to stop and look up."



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